

FREE SAMPLE · THREE DEVOTIONS

THE GOD WHO *Hears Her*

*Being known by God through
the women of Genesis*



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Welcome

Thank you for opening this. What follows are three devotions from *The God Who Hears Her*, a sixty-day journey through the women of Genesis.

I have chosen Hagar for your sample, and I chose her on purpose. She is an outsider, a slave and a foreigner, afflicted by the very covenant family that should have sheltered her. She is also the first person in all of Scripture to give God a name. If God met her in the wilderness—and He did, twice—then there is no wilderness where He will not meet you.

These pages are not a tidy study. The stories of the women of Genesis are complex, nuanced and often painful, and I have tried not to look away from any of it. What I have found, again and again, is that God does not look away either.

You are seen. You are heard. Read on.

WHAT EACH DEVOTION GIVES YOU

- **Scripture first.** Every devotion opens with the passage itself, not a paraphrase of it.

- **Honest reflection.** These women are not tidied up, and neither are we.
- **A question to carry.** Each day ends with something to sit with rather than solve.

— Dr. Connie Champeon

Affliction

“...When she [Hagar] saw that she had conceived, her mistress was despised in her eyes... Sarai dealt harshly with her, and she fled from her face. The LORD’s angel found her by a fountain of water in the wilderness, by the fountain on the way to Shur. He said, “Hagar, Sarai’s servant, where did you come from? Where are you going?” She said, “I am fleeing from the face of my mistress Sarai.”” (Genesis 16:4-8)

The first day I started studying Hagar I thought, “I’m not feeling up to this; maybe I’ll jump ahead to someone easier.” Then I started thinking and realized there are very few, if any, easy, uncomplicated women’s stories that I could jump to, so I decided to keep going and not look away. The name Hagar means “sojourner” or “the stranger”. The Bible doesn’t say if Sarai and Abram give her this name or if it is her given name. Either way, she is an outsider, and her name constantly reminds her of that. Her life is the anti-exodus. The Israelites are afflicted in Egypt; they cry out and go into the wilderness where God provides water. Hagar is an Egyptian who is afflicted by the Covenant people and flees into the wilderness. The word that God used to describe how Sarai *afflicts/deals harshly* with Hagar is the same Hebrew word used in Genesis 15:13 to describe the affliction that will happen to

Abram's descendants in Egypt. Truly God's heart is always with the afflicted, whether it is His Covenant people who are being afflicted or whether it is outsiders who are afflicted by His Covenant people.

It is so easy to justify my own actions when I treat people harshly. Do I extend to others the same grace that God extends to me? When I mess up, I don't want God to punish me harshly, but I feel I'm right to do it to others. I have both experienced and observed that people in the church are often particularly harsh to teenagers. Yet Christians wonder why teens flee from the church as soon as they can. We've taught them it's only a place for rule-keepers, that if they can't get their act together there is no grace or help to be found within it. It's no surprise they flee to the wilderness. Do I act like my Father and seek out the afflicted in the wilderness? Do I offer hope, help and guidance?

Then there is the other side of this story. Often I find myself alone in the wilderness wondering how I ended up here again. Sometimes this is because of the wrongs of others. Sometimes it is the sin of my own doing. Often in my own life, it is both, as it is in this passage. No matter the cause, God meets me there. And like He did to Hagar, God asks me, "What are you doing here? Where do you think you are going?" God spends a lot of time with His people in the wilderness - in the Bible and with me. When I have nothing left to try and no strength

left of my own, I am finally able to listen. Thank you, Father,
that you are always present for your sons and your daughters.

The Outsider Ezer \- a Wilderness Theologian

“...The LORD’s angel said to her, “Return to your mistress, and submit yourself under her hands.” The LORD’s angel said to her, “I will greatly multiply your offspring, that they will not be counted for multitude.” The LORD’s angel said to her, “Behold, you are with child, and will bear a son. You shall call his name Ishmael, because the LORD has heard your affliction. He will be like a wild donkey among men. His hand will be against every man, and every man’s hand against him. He will live opposed to all of his brothers.”

“She called the name of the LORD who spoke to her, “You are a God who sees,” for she said, “Have I even stayed alive after seeing him?” Therefore the well was called Beer Lahai Roi. Behold, it is between Kadesh and Bered.”” (Genesis 16:11-14)

Two women in the Bible name God, Hagar and Hannah. They both give God a descriptive title based on their personal experience of His character. The contrast with how men name God and how women name God is fascinating. Abraham, Jacob, Moses, and Gideon all act as memorializers when naming God. They are essentially claiming a physical piece of ground for God. When they witness a miracle, they name that specific location after the characteristic God just revealed. Abraham names the place where God provided a ram, “The Lord will Provide.” After wrestling with God, Jacob sets up an

altar and names it, “God, the God of Israel.” Moses names the altar he builds after they defeat the Amalekites, “The Lord is my banner.” And after Gideon survives the encounter with the angel, he builds an altar and names it “The Lord is Peace.”

It’s easy to see how different these men’s encounters are from the women’s. While the men named locations, Hagar calls Him the God who sees her, and Hannah—crying out in her deep grief—is the first person in Scripture to call Him, “the Lord of Hosts.” That title literally means the Lord of *armies*. It’s amazing that a brokenhearted woman in her deepest personal pain is the one who claims the Lord’s absolute military power.

The contrast between the men mapping territory and the women naming God could be a major scholarly study on its own—and honestly, it probably has been. The women give God a new personal name or title, while the men name the location of their divine encounter. There is a strength to how men claim places and make monuments to what God has done. These become reminders to them and to us of who God is. But there is also an incredible intimacy and beauty in how these women name God. They aren’t just building an altar; they are describing the God who met them right where they were.

Hagar's name for God is descriptive and personal. God stands in stark contrast to the transactional Egyptian deities she once knew. He is personal and present. This God of Abram even sees a slave, a stranger who is far from home. In her background, a deity was always tied to a certain location and often to a certain kind of object or creature - mountains, rivers, snakes, crocodiles, etc. The wilderness where Hagar has fled should belong to the gods of the Canaanites, not to Abram's God. Also, there is no object He is manifesting Himself through. Everything about His seeing her is unlike anything she used to know about how gods work. This God is not even just Abram's God, because Abram is far away, but his God is caring for her personally. There is certainly no other god who sees the afflicted.

In some ways, it is ironic that Hagar is used in Galatians to represent the old Covenant. There she represents the Covenant of works and the flesh rather than the Covenant of promise. But here she is a foreshadowing of the New Covenant. The first person to actually name God is a Gentile, a slave, and a woman. Two types of divine encounters are shown in Sarah and Hagar's stories. Sarah provides the structure of the Covenant line, but Hagar provides the scope of the Covenant - God is for everyone.

One final, amazing thing about Hagar's naming of God is that it does not reflect an immediate victory or an easy rescue. In

fact, the story doesn't end with a clean escape because the angel tells her to go right back and submit to her mistress. In today's world, the call to voluntarily return to a place of injustice and affliction feels completely radical to us, maybe even offensive to our survival instincts. Why would God send her back to that?

I suspect the seeing and the returning are directly linked. Being fully seen and heard by God must have been exactly what gave her the supernatural strength and courage to walk back into that mess and survive there for the next 17 years until her son was grown. Her outward circumstances didn't change right away, but knowing she wasn't invisible to the Creator of the universe changed how she faced them. That one desert encounter gave her the fuel for nearly two decades of daily survival. And she didn't carry only her own name for God back into Sarai's tent. Two names were given in that wilderness. God named the boy first — Ishmael, "God hears." Then Hagar responded with a name of her own: *You are a God who sees me*. One name for what He did with His eyes, one for what He did with His ears. For the next seventeen years, Hagar would say "God hears" out loud every time she called her son.

Deep down in my soul, do I know that He is the only one who truly sees and hears me? Does that fill me with awe? Am I amazed by His terrifying power, and does it daily fill me with

hope that a God who is that powerful sees me? Is my response to His deliverance to marvel at who He is or to go on to my next need?

DAY THREE

The Provider in the Wilderness

“Abraham rose up early in the morning, and took bread and a container of water, and gave it to Hagar, putting it on her shoulder; and gave her the child, and sent her away. She departed, and wandered in the wilderness of Beersheba. The water in the container was spent, and she put the child under one of the shrubs. She went and sat down opposite him, a good way off, about a bow shot away. For she said, “Don’t let me see the death of the child.” She sat opposite him, and lifted up her voice, and wept. God heard the voice of the boy.

“The angel of God called to Hagar out of the sky, and said to her, “What troubles you, Hagar? Don’t be afraid. For God has heard the voice of the boy where he is. Get up, lift up the boy, and hold him with your hand. For I will make him a great nation.” God opened her eyes, and she saw a well of water. She went, filled the container with water, and gave the boy a drink. God was with the boy, and he grew. He lived in the wilderness, and as he grew up, he became an archer.” (Genesis 21:14-20)

In the Ancient Near East, 17 was the age of manhood. It is interesting that both Ishmael and Joseph faced death from those who should have been protecting them at this age. Both were abused by the Covenant people who should have behaved differently than the world around them, and God

was with them both. Like Hagar, Ishmael's story is an anti-exodus. Yes, God told Abraham to send them away, but with only a container of water and some bread heading into the Negev desert?! It was more like a death sentence. Why didn't he send them with a donkey laden with enough provisions to set up home somewhere else and pay Hagar for her years of service? Sending them away was obeying God, but, even by Ancient Near East legal standards, he should have given Hagar much more. Abraham's emotional distress did not translate into generosity or actually doing something to help her. The system failed Hagar. The Patriarch (Abraham) failed to protect. The household's leading *ezer* (Sarah) turned into an oppressor. *But God...* But God used Abraham's failure to prove that He is a better provider than the "Father of Faith."

"God opened her eyes, and she saw a well of water." God didn't miraculously create water; He opened Hagar's eyes to what was already there. God has taught me this lesson so many times in wilderness places. When I have a season of scarcity, grief, or being cast out in some way, I'm often praying for a way out and miraculous provision. Instead God opens my eyes to see what He has already given me. Tears and trauma can blind me to what God has set right in front of me. I need to see that what He has already put in my hand is His gift. Often it is also His solution to the overwhelming experience that I am having.

“She sat opposite him, and lifted up her voice, and wept. God heard the voice of the boy.” Hagar is the one weeping, but it is the boy's voice God hears. That is not a small thing! Seventeen years earlier, in this same wilderness, the angel told her to name her son Ishmael “because the LORD has heard your affliction.” His name is the memorial of the day God heard *her*. So for seventeen years, she has said aloud the words “God hears” over and over as she called her son. And now, when she is too far gone to pray and can only weep, God answers to the name He Himself gave. Hagar is holding the proof of God's hearing in her arms as she sits down to watch Ishmael die.

This is the same mercy as she received at the well. There God opened her eyes to water that was already there; here He fulfilled a promise that was already there. Like Hagar, the noise of my current crisis is often too loud in my head for me to hear God's promises. My present reality may cause me to despair, so I don't trust that God is legally and relationally bound by His own character to provide for me. Or, I may be afraid His provision won't be good enough, great enough, or soon enough. But His hearing doesn't depend on my hearing. What He has already said is still true even while I am weeping too hard to remember it.

The Covenant family failed Hagar, but the reality is God often steps in where religious communities fail. God's most intimate encounters often happen outside the camp, where

people have been cast out and abused by religious systems. Don't focus on those systems; this may be the wilderness that is necessary for us to hear the voice of God personally. As someone who is mostly inside the camp, I must never be the reason someone else is alone and without provisions when they are in the wilderness. I need to keep reaching out, keep loving them, and keep offering them help and hope. This is true even though this process is often messy and hard, and it would be easier to walk away.

KEEP READING

These three devotions are part of a sixty-day journey through the women of Genesis— Sarah, Hagar, Rebekah, Leah, Rachel, Dinah, Tamar and the many unnamed women whose cries God recorded.

For release news and occasional encouragement, stay on the list at

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